combat effectiveness of troops depends in good part on officer leadership. Is there any reason to think that Chinese officers are lacking in the qualities needed to lead their units? Finally, and perhaps most importantly, if the Chinese military relies heavily on weapons that can be deployed and manipulated remotely, this may compensate for any weaknesses in the combat effectiveness of their troops. As noted earlier, the utility of these technologies at those heights and in difficult terrain of the Himalaya is unknown, but it would be imprudent to discount their impact.

Soft Power

China has a massive economic lead over India, and there is no prospect of India reducing the gap significantly in the next three decades. The Chinese military is superior in key areas, but the difference is not decisive given the limitations arising out of geography and strategy. The most marked difference in military power is due to China's indigenous defence production and possibly the new technologies and forms of warfare that it is developing. India could reduce the military gap over the next two or three decades with the new self-reliance programme of Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan. If China leads India in hard power, above all in economic power, what about soft power, the ability to persuade without force or coercion? Here too, surprisingly, China has a lead over India, one that looks set to persist for a good long time.

In 2012, the Indian politician and former UN official Shashi Tharoor spoke at the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy in Singapore. He drew on his book *Pax Indica: India and the World of the 21st Century*, which had just been published. Among the propositions he advanced for India's greater role in the world was its soft power – its ability to persuade by attracting others to its values, institutions, and achievements. When challenged on this score, including on the issue of admiration for India's democracy in Asia, Tharoor inimitably and humorously responded that the questioner – this author – was assessing the regard for India's democratic achievements